

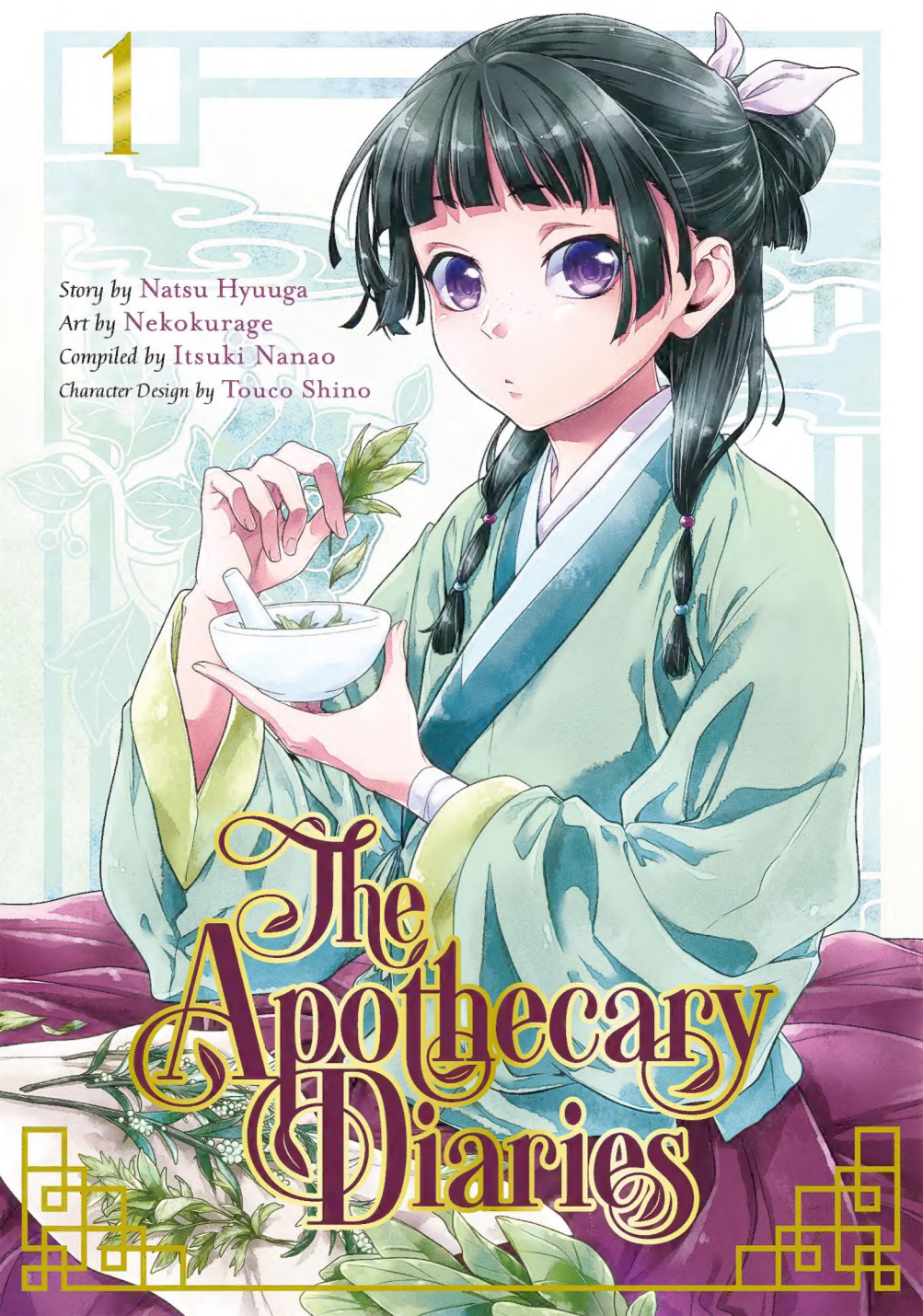
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Story by Natsu Hyuuga

Art by Nekokurage

Compiled by Itsuki Nanao

Character Design by Touco Shino



# The Apothecary Diaries

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# The Apothecary Diaries

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...I WAS  
MADE OFF  
WITH MOST  
INCONVE-  
NIENTLY BY  
KIDNAPPERS.

ONE DAY,  
WHEN I  
WAS OUT  
IN THE  
FOREST  
PICKING  
MEDICINAL  
HERBS...



I HOPE  
YOU'RE  
EATING  
PROPERLY  
...

DAD  
...

HAAH...



IT'S  
ALREADY  
BEEN  
THREE  
MONTHS  
SINCE  
THEN...

DEPRESSED  
ちーん



BEAUTIFUL  
ROBES,  
FAKE  
SMILES...

THE  
STIFLING  
REEK OF  
COSMET-  
ICS...

...ARE  
NOT ALL  
THAT DIFF-  
ERENT.

THE  
PALACE  
AND THE  
PLEASURE  
DISTRICT...

...THE  
INNER  
COURT IS  
SEPARATED  
FROM THE  
REST OF THE  
PALACE.

A  
GARDEN OF  
WOMEN TO  
BEAR THE  
EMPEROR'S  
CHILDREN...

...AND THE  
EUNUCHS...

...THOSE  
WHO,  
HAVING  
LOST A  
CERTAIN  
"TREASURE,"  
ARE NO  
LONGER  
CONSIDERED  
MEN.

THE ONLY  
EXCEPTIONS  
TO THE RULE  
ARE THE  
EMPEROR  
HIMSELF,  
HIS BLOOD  
RELATIONS...

MEN ARE  
EXPLICITLY  
FORBIDDEN  
TO ENTER.



IT JUST  
HAD TO  
HAPPEN  
WHEN I'D  
FINALLY  
BECOME  
AN APOTHE-  
ECARY  
TOO...

WHETHER  
I WAS  
SOLD INTO  
SERVITUDE OR  
SENT IN THE  
PLACE OF  
ANOTHER,  
I KNOW  
NOT...

BUT I'D  
HOPED TO  
LIVE OUT MY  
YEARS NEVER  
ONCE GETTING  
INVOLVED WITH  
THE INNER  
COURT.



THE  
NEXT ONE  
IS FOR THAT  
LOW-RANKING  
CONCUBINE  
WHO'S  
ALWAYS  
COOPED  
UP IN HER  
CHAMBERS,  
HMM?



LIKE  
HER,  
MOST  
OF THE  
WOMEN  
HERE  
CAN'T  
READ.



TEACHING  
EVEN HALF  
OF THESE  
COUNTRY  
GIRLS  
TO READ  
WOULD BE  
QUITE THE  
ACHIEVE-  
MENT.

...BUT  
EDU-  
CATION  
IS A  
WHOLE  
OTHER  
STORY.

IN  
PREPARA-  
TION TO  
WORK  
AT THE  
PALACE,  
ETIQUETTE  
IS DRILLED  
INTO  
EVERYONE  
BEFORE-  
HAND...



...GONE  
ON TO  
BECOME  
LOW-  
RANKING  
CONCU-  
BINES.

DESPITE  
THIS,  
MAIDS  
LIKE  
MYSELF  
HAVE, ON  
RARE  
OCCA-  
SIONS...





ALL  
YOU  
NEED  
...

FRECKLES

...IS A  
PRETTY  
FACE.

FLAT  
AS A  
BOARD

NOT THAT.  
I'M INTERESTED  
OR ANYTHING...

...YOU CAN  
COUNT ME  
OUT.

FRECKLED FACE  
AND A SKINNY  
FRAME



SO...

...I'M FINE  
STICKING  
WITH WHAT  
I'M DOING  
NOW.

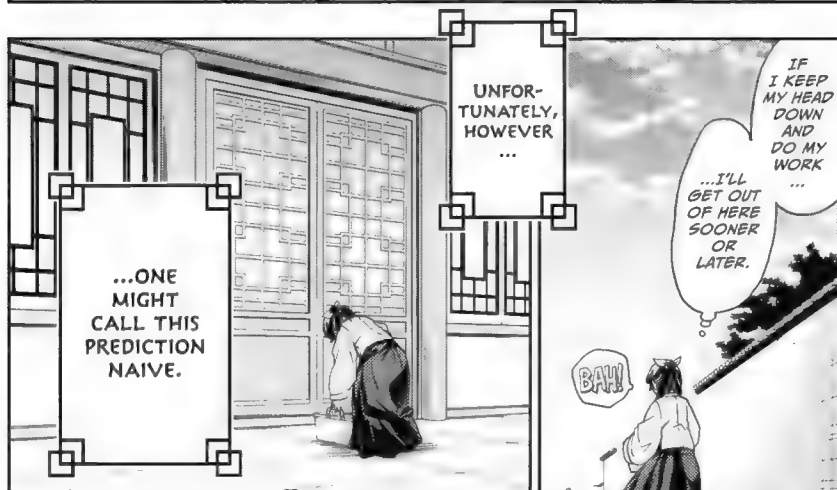
EVEN  
IF YOU  
CAN READ,  
IT JUST  
MEANS  
THERE'S  
MORE  
WORK  
WAITING  
FOR YOU...

...WHEN  
ALL'S  
SAID  
AND  
DONE.



...WOULD  
ONLY  
SERVE  
TO FURTHER  
LINE THE  
POCKETS  
OF MY  
ABDUCTORS,  
AFTER ALL.

AN  
INCREASE  
IN MY  
WAGES...

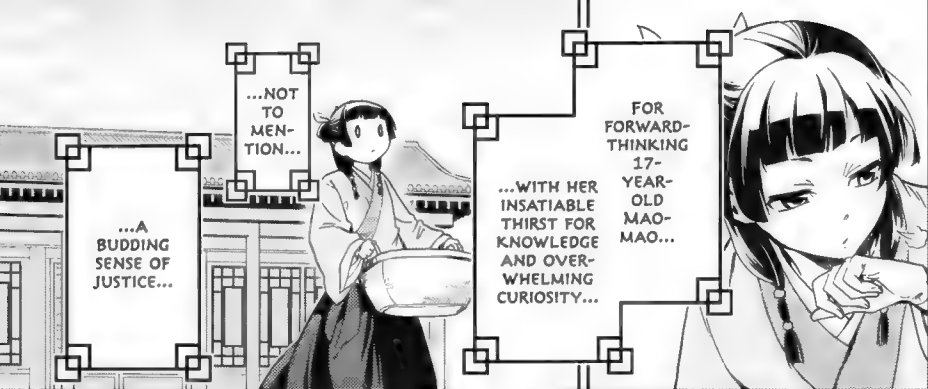


...ONE  
MIGHT  
CALL THIS  
PREDICTION  
NAIVE.

UNFOR-  
TUNATELY,  
HOWEVER  
...

IF  
I KEEP  
MY HEAD  
DOWN  
AND  
DO MY  
WORK  
...  
...I'LL  
GET OUT  
OF HERE  
SOONER  
OR  
LATER.

BAH!



**RUMORS  
SPREAD  
LIKE  
WILDFIRE  
IN THE  
IMPERIAL  
COURT.**

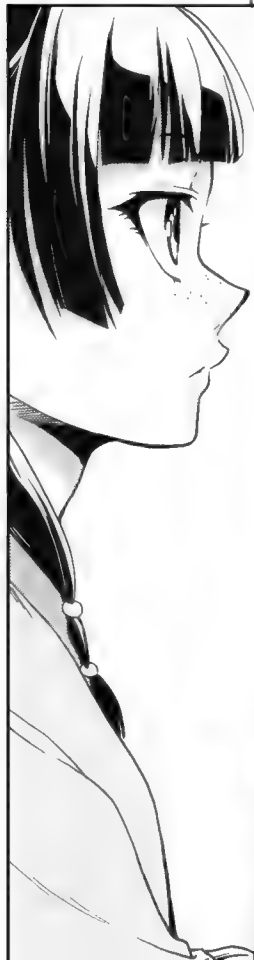
...WHAT  
ARE YOU  
TALKING  
ABOUT?



**YOU  
MEAN  
YOU  
HAVEN'T  
HEARD?!**



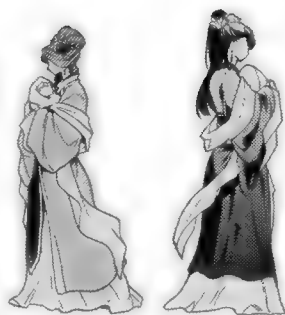
**THE  
HEIRS  
BORN  
IN THE  
INNER  
COURT  
KEEP  
DYING,  
ONE  
AFTER  
THE  
OTHER!**





...ARE  
STILL  
ALIVE.

...AND A SIX-  
MONTH-OLD  
PRINCESS...



AT  
PRES-  
ENT...

...THE  
CROWN  
PRINCE,  
WHO IS  
THREE  
MONTHS  
OLD...

HOW-  
EVER...

THE  
CROWN  
PRINCE'S  
MOTHER IS  
CONSORT  
LIHUA...

...WHO  
MAKES HER  
RESIDENCE  
IN THE  
BIGGEST  
PALACE IN  
THE INNER  
COURT.

RIGHT  
NOW, THE  
EMPEROR  
DOESN'T  
HAVE AN  
EMPRESS,  
SO...

...YOU MIGHT  
SAY THAT THE  
MOTHER OF THE  
CROWN PRINCE  
POSSESSES  
THE MOST  
POWER.

...IT  
SEEMS THE  
EMPEROR  
FAVORS...

...CONSORT  
GYOKUYO,  
MOTHER  
TO THE  
PRINCESS.







...AND HAS  
EVEN BEEN  
SUFFERING  
FROM  
NAUSEA.

SHE'S  
BEEN  
GIVEN  
TO HEAD-  
ACHES AND  
STOMACH  
PAINS...

SO I'M  
TOLD.

HEADACHES,  
STOMACHACHES,  
AND NAUSEA?



MAYBE  
I'LL  
JUST  
GO TAKE  
A PEEK  
AT HOW  
THEY'RE  
DOING.



THIS  
IS MERE  
CONJEC-  
TURE ON  
MY PART.

...AND  
YET...

WHAT AM  
I DOING,  
TAKING A  
RUMOR SO  
SERIOUSLY?

GASP





WITH THE DINING HALLS AND THE GARDENS INCLUDED, THIS PLACE IS EVEN LARGER THAN SOME TOWNS.

IT'S FULL OF PALACES, OUTBUILDINGS, AND COUNTLESS ROOMS.

THE INNER COURT IS, IN A WORD, HUGE.



EVEN THE INDIVIDUAL PILLARS HERE ARE MORE ELEGANT THAN THOSE ON THE EASTERN SIDE OF THE COURT...



I'D EXPECT NO LESS FROM THE PLACE THAT HOUSES THE OFFSPRING OF THE HIGH-RANKING CONSORTS ...



IT'S BIG ON THE INSIDE TOO.



SLAP

THIS IS ALL YOUR DOING!



HMM?

MURMUR

...SO  
SURELY  
YOU  
KNOW  
THAT'S  
NOT  
TRUE.

MY  
XIAOLING  
SUFFERS  
IN THE  
SAME  
WAY...

CONSORT  
GYOKUYO

YOU  
BORE A  
DAUGH-  
TER...

...SO  
NOW YOU  
INTEND TO  
KILL MY  
SON WITH  
THIS VILE  
CURSE,  
DON'T  
YOU?!

CONSORT  
LIHUA





HEADACHES,  
STOMACH-  
ACHES,  
NAUSEA...

INFANT  
DEATHS  
...



THIS IS  
ABSO-  
LUTELY  
NOT...



CONSORT  
LIHUA'S  
HAGGARD  
APPEAR-  
ANCE...

AND  
MOST  
TELLING  
OF  
ALL...



...A CURSE OF ANY KIND.



LESS THAN  
A MONTH  
AFTER THAT  
INCIDENT...

...THE  
CROWN  
PRINCE  
PASSED  
AWAY.

THEY  
DON'T  
GIVE US  
MUCH IN  
THE BEST  
OF TIMES,  
BUT  
STILL...

THIS  
ISN'T  
NEARLY  
ENOUGH  
TO EAT.

THERE'S  
NO  
MEAT IN  
THIS.

CHATTER  
か  
や

CHATTER  
か  
や



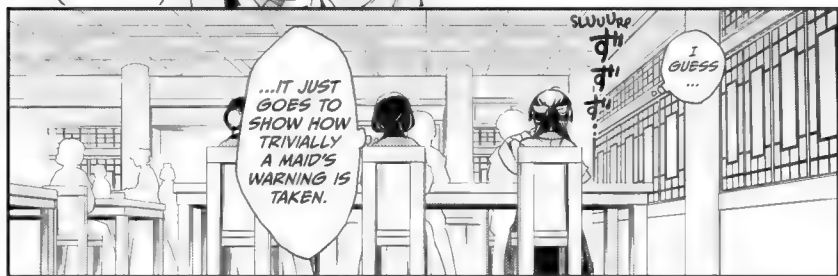
...AND LEFT THEM FOR EACH OF THE CONSORTS.

...I ATTACHED SIMPLE NOTES TO RHODODENDRON BRANCHES ...



THAT DAY...

BUT IT APPEARS THAT MY EFFORTS WERE IN VAIN.



...IT JUST GOES TO SHOW HOW TRIVIAL A MAID'S WARNING IS TAKEN.

SHURE  
す  
す  
す

I GUESS ...



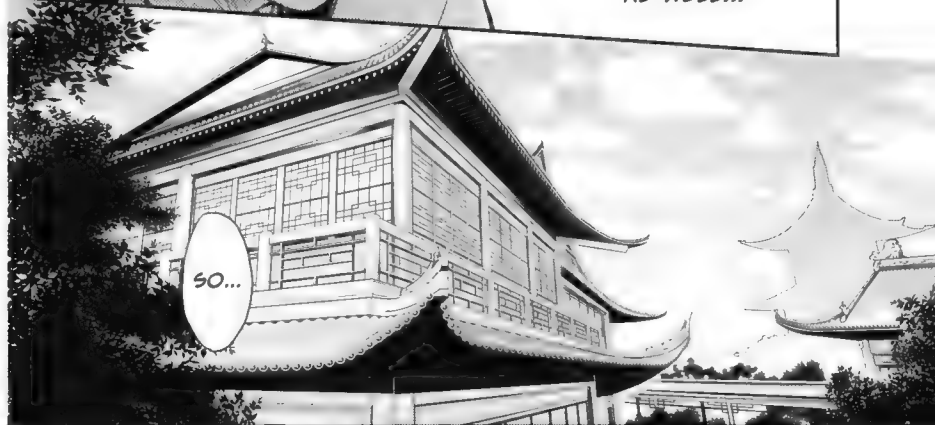
AFTER LOSING HER SON, CONSORT LIHUA...

...FADED SO MUCH THAT NOT EVEN A SHADOW...

...OF HER FORMER BEAUTY REMAINS.



I SUPPOSE  
IT'S ONLY A  
MATTER OF  
TIME UNTIL  
CONSORT  
GYOKUYO'S  
DAUGHTER  
PASSES AWAY  
AS WELL...

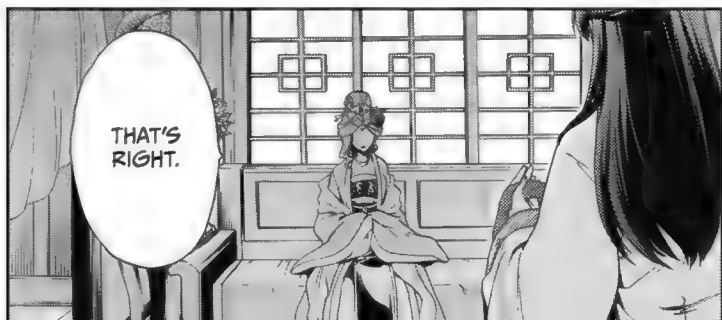


SO...



YES.

...SOMEONE  
LEFT THIS  
FOR YOU  
RIGHT AFTER  
THAT OPEN  
DISPUTE?



THAT'S  
RIGHT.

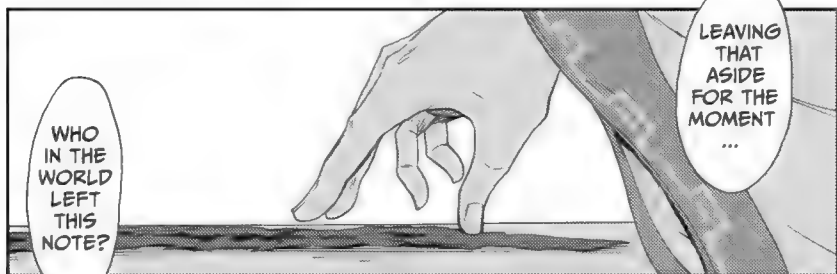


I AS  
WELL.



IGNO-  
RANCE  
IS A  
SIN.

I  
SHOULD  
HAVE  
TAKEN  
MORE  
CARE...  
...OF  
WHAT  
COULD  
GO INTO  
MY BABY'S  
MOUTH.



WHO  
IN THE  
WORLD  
LEFT  
THIS  
NOTE?

LEAVING  
THAT  
ASIDE  
FOR THE  
MOMENT  
...

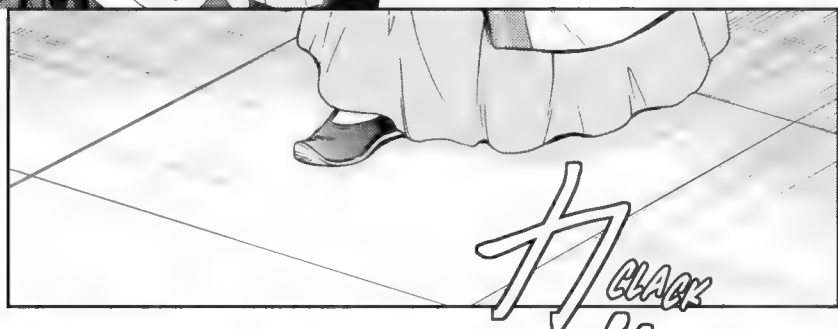


MY  
LADY...

WHAT  
WILL  
YOU  
DO...

...WHEN WE  
FIND THE  
SENDER?







OOOH

HM? WAIT,  
THOSE  
SHOULDERS  
ARE  
PRETTY  
BROAD.

A  
MAN?

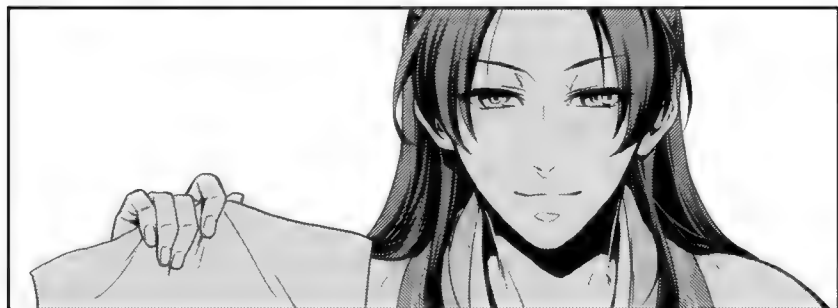
THAT'S  
TOO  
BAD.

SWISH  
スィッシュ

HUH?

SWISH  
スィッシュ

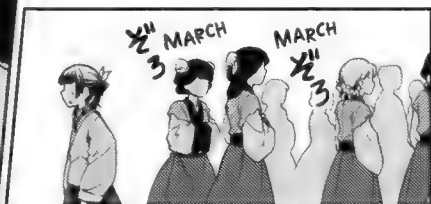
!





GASP

OH,  
THAT'S  
RIGHT!!



MARCH

MARCH



AM  
I BEING  
SINGLED  
OUT  
BECAUSE  
OF SOME  
MAJOR  
ERROR?

...THIS  
CAN'T BE  
ABOUT  
THE  
NOTES,  
CAN IT?



WHOA,  
THERE.

LOOM

...I'M THE  
ONLY MAID  
IN THIS  
ROOM  
WHO CAN  
READ!!



I AM  
JINSHI.

I THOUGHT  
I TOLD YOU  
TO STAY PUT,  
HMM?

COME  
ALONG  
QUIETLY,  
NOW.

ORR...

...HE  
CAUGHT  
ME.











THERE  
APPEARS  
TO HAVE  
BEEN SOME  
KIND OF  
MISUNDER-  
STANDING.

I BELIEVE  
MY LADY  
MIGHT BE  
MISTAKING  
ME FOR ANOTHER.



CONSORT  
GYOKUYO  
ENTRUSTED  
A CERTAIN  
SOMETHING  
INTO MY  
CARE,  
YOU  
SEE.

NOW  
WHERE  
DID IT  
GO?!

JOLT

RUSTLE

AHEM!

RUSTLE



HERE  
WE  
ARE.

SWISH  
すっ



DOES THIS  
CLOTH LOOK  
TO YOU LIKE  
IT'S FROM A  
MAIDSERVANT'S  
UNIFORM?

"THE FACE POWDER IS POISON.  
DO NOT EXPOSE YOUR BABY TO IT."

IN-  
DEED.

COULD  
BE, NOW  
THAT YOU  
MENTION  
IT.

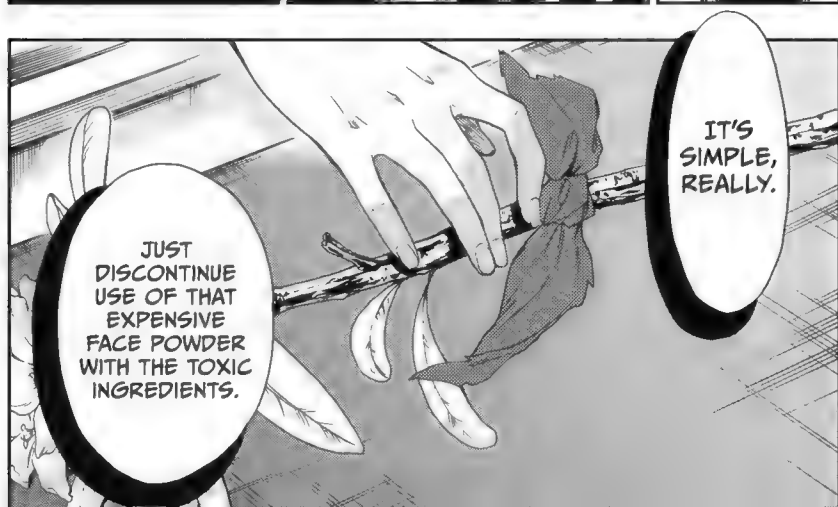
YOUR  
SKIRT  
WOULDN'T  
HAPPEN TO  
BE MISSING  
A PIECE,  
WOULD  
IT?

FWIP

IT  
BELONGS  
TO THE  
UNIFORM  
OF A  
SHANG-FU  
MAID.\*

#  
JOLT

\*SHANG-FU: WARDROBE SERVICES, SUCH AS LAUNDRY.







I  
JUST...

...HAPPENED  
TO SEE  
FIRSTHAND  
THE FATE THAT  
AWAITED THE  
COURTE-  
SANS...

...WHO  
REFUSED  
TO STOP  
WEARING  
THE  
POWDER.



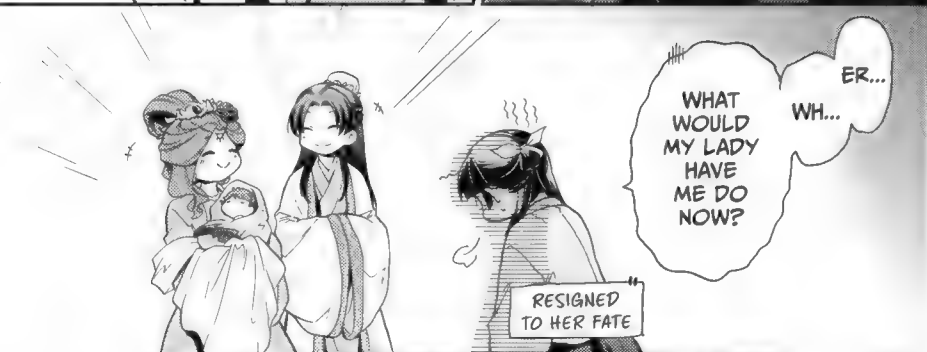
...AND  
FOR  
THAT,  
THEY  
LOST  
BOTH.

I WAS  
REMINDED  
OF WHAT  
HAPPENED  
TO THEM.  
THAT'S  
ALL.



THEY  
WEIGHED  
THEIR  
LIVES  
EQUALLY  
WITH  
THEIR  
BEAUTY  
...





...YOU'LL  
BE MY NEW  
LADY-IN-  
WAITING!

...FROM  
THIS DAY  
FORTH...

WELL,  
I GUESS  
YOU  
MIGHT  
SAY I'VE  
GOTTEN  
MYSELF A  
PROMO-  
TION.

UH...

HUH  
...?

Chapter 2



NOT  
JUST  
ANYONE  
CAN BE  
EMPLOYED  
AS ONE  
OF HER  
ATTEN-  
DANTS.



SHE  
IS ALSO  
WISE AND  
CAUTIOUS.

CONSORT  
GYOKUYO  
HAS A  
BRIGHT,  
GENTLE  
PERSON-  
ALITY.

...OR  
ELSE NO  
MATTER HOW  
MANY LIVES  
SHE HAS,  
THEY WOULD  
NEVER BE  
ENOUGH.

...MUST BE  
GREATLY  
WARE OF  
THOSE  
AROUND  
HER...

THE  
FAVORITE  
OF THE  
EMPEROR  
...





CONSORT  
GYOKUYO  
CURRENTLY  
HAS FOUR  
LADIES-IN-  
WAITING.



BY  
CONTRAST,  
CONSORT  
LIHUA HAS  
OVER TEN.

THUS,  
CONSORT  
GYOKUYO  
IS RATHER  
LACKING IN  
ATTENDANTS  
FOR SOME-  
ONE OF  
SO HIGH  
A RANK.

AS  
THINGS  
STAND,  
IT'S HARD  
FOR HER  
TO OWN  
THE  
DIGNITY  
OF HER  
STATION.



I'D BEEN  
HOPING TO  
ASSIGN HER  
AT LEAST  
ONE MORE  
ATTENDANT...



...WOULD  
NEVER  
REJECT THE  
PERSON WHO  
SAVED THE  
PRINCESS'S  
LIFE.

I'M  
CERTAIN  
CONSORT  
GYOKUYO  
...

THAT  
MAID  
REALLY  
DID HAVE  
GREAT  
TIMING.



IF SHE  
ATTEMPTS  
TO USE THAT  
KNOW-HOW  
FOR ILL...

...I'LL  
JUST HAVE  
TO HERD  
HER INTO  
A POST  
WHERE  
SUCH  
KNOW-  
LEDGE  
WILL BE  
USELESS.

AFTER  
ALL...

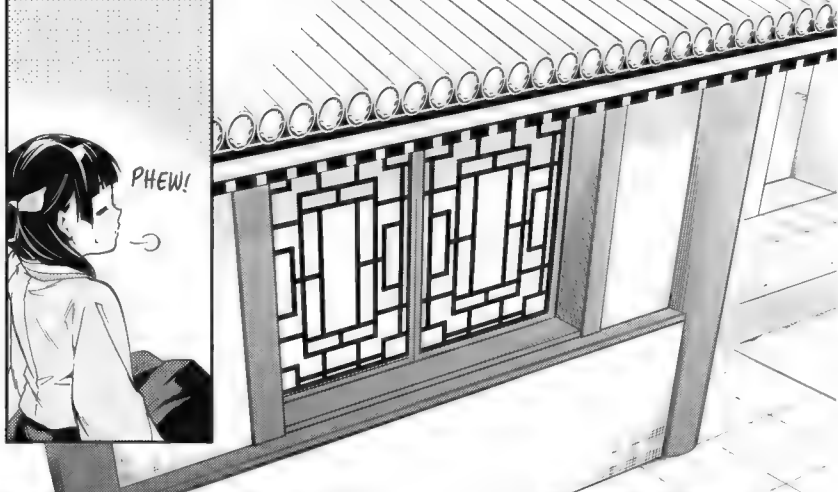
...HOW  
COULD  
I FAIL TO  
PUT THAT  
FRECKLE-  
FACE AND  
HER POISON  
EXPERTISE  
TO WORK?



AND JUST IN  
CASE, AIMING  
A FEW SULTRY  
GAZES HER  
WAY MIGHT  
NOT HURT  
EITHER.

Chapter 2 The Mad Scientist







...WHAT  
CAN I  
HELP  
WITH?

I'VE  
FINISHED  
PUTTING  
AWAY MY  
THINGS,  
SO...

OH!



A FEW  
HOURS  
EARLIER

EX-  
CUSE  
ME...



おしやる  
PUSH

YOU JUST  
GO BACK  
TO YOUR  
ROOM  
NOW.

おしやる おしやる  
PUSH PUSH

おしやる..  
PUSH

WE  
ALREADY  
HAD IT ALL  
HANDLED  
BEFORE  
YOU CAME  
ALONG  
ANYWAY.

IT'S FINE!  
DON'T YOU  
WORRY  
ABOUT A  
THING.



SOME  
LEFTOVER  
SWEETS  
FROM TEA  
EARLIER...

YOU  
CAN  
HAVE  
THEM.

AND  
HERE.





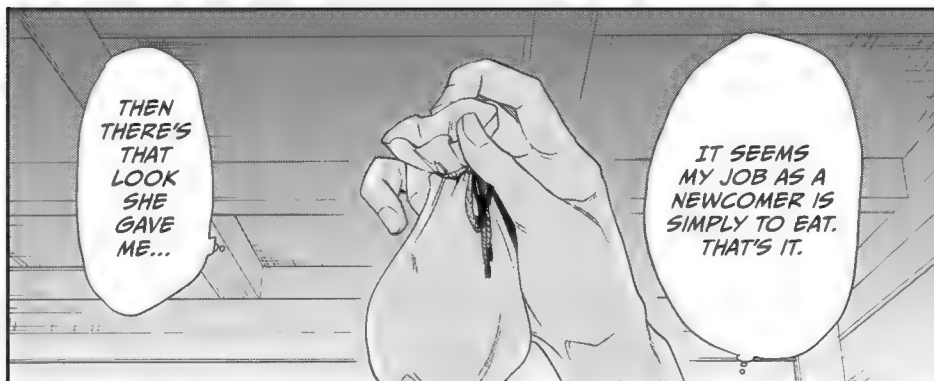
THE WET NURSE MUST'VE BEEN THE ONE USING IT HERE IN THE JADE PALACE.

...CONSORT GYOKUYO WASN'T WEARING ANY FACE POWDER DURING THAT CONFRONTATION.

WHEN I THINK ABOUT IT...

ALSO, WITH THE PRINCESS STARTING ON SOLID FOOD...

...ONE OF THE WET NURSES WAS LET GO, I'M TOLD.



THEN THERE'S THAT LOOK SHE GAVE ME...

IT SEEMS MY JOB AS A NEWCOMER IS SIMPLY TO EAT. THAT'S IT.



...BUT THAT EXPRESSION...

...SO I WASN'T EXPECTING TO BE WELCOMED WITH WARMTH AND SMILES ...

I KNOW ONLY A SELECT FEW GET TO WORK HERE, TO BEGIN WITH...





...PASSES  
THROUGH  
MULTIPLE  
HANDS  
BEFORE  
ARRIVING  
AT HER  
CHAMBERS.



EVERY  
ONE OF  
THE CON-  
SORT'S  
MEALS...

...THERE'S  
ALWAYS A  
CHANCE THAT  
SOMEONE HAS  
ATTEMPTED  
TO POISON  
HER FOOD  
ALONG THE  
WAY.



SINCE  
SHE'S  
THE EMPE-  
ROR'S FA-  
VOR-  
ITE...



ON ONE  
OCCASION,  
THE FOOD  
TASTER  
SURVIVED  
A MINOR  
ILLNESS.

ON  
THE OTHER,  
THE TASTER  
EXPERIENCED  
NERVE  
DAMAGE AND  
PERMANENT  
PARALYSIS  
IN HER ARMS  
AND LEGS.



WHEN  
SHE WAS  
PREGNANT  
WITH THE  
PRINCESS  
...



SINCE  
I'VE COME  
HERE SPE-  
CIFICALLY  
TO BE  
A FOOD  
TASTER...

THE  
CROWN  
PRINCE'S  
DEMISE  
MUST HAVE  
EVERYONE  
ON EDGE.

...I'M TOLD  
TWO SUCH  
ATTEMPTS  
WERE MADE  
ON HER  
LIFE.



...OF  
COURSE  
THEY'D SEE  
ME AS A  
PAWN WHO  
WON'T BE  
HERE  
LONG.

NO  
WONDER  
THEY TURN  
THOSE  
PITYING  
GAZES  
ON ME.





NO ABNORMALITIES IN  
COLOR...

SNIFF

NO  
OFF  
ODORS  
...

NO  
NUMBING  
SENSATION  
EITHER...

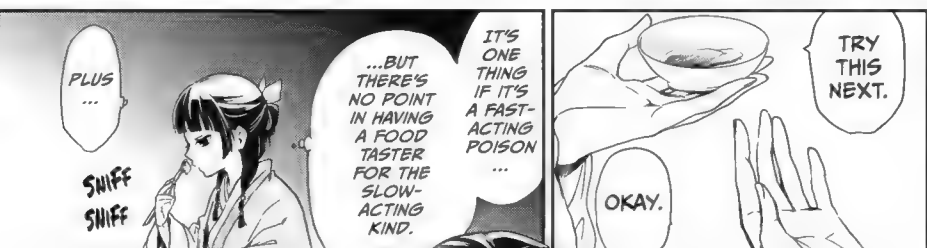
...IF  
POISON  
IS SUCH  
A GRAVE  
CONCERN,  
THEY REALLY  
OUGHT TO  
LOOK INTO  
USING  
SILVER  
DISHES.

ANY-  
WAY...

もぐ  
MUNCH

MUNCH  
もぐ



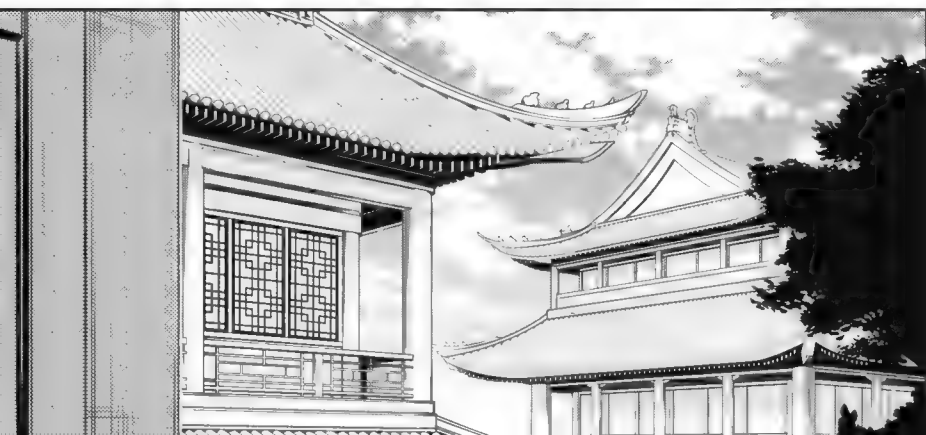




...SO THE TRUTH IS, I'M NOT TERRIBLY SUITABLE FOR THIS WORK.

I SLOWLY BUILT UP A TOLERANCE TO POISONS ...







HAAH...

HEAD  
LADY-IN-WAITING  
HONGNIANG

I WOULD  
SUGGEST  
DISHES OF  
SILVER BE  
USED FROM  
NOW ON.



HM?

WE  
PURPOSELY  
AVOIDED  
USING SILVER  
THIS TIME,  
YOU SEE.

IT'S  
JUST AS  
JINSHI  
SAID.



SO IT  
WAS ALL A  
PART OF HIS  
SCHEME...

URGH!







WHAT'S WORSE,  
WE'LL PROBABLY  
HAVE TO BILL YOU  
FOR THIS AS WELL.



YOU WON'T  
BE ABLE TO PAY  
THIS BACK ON YOUR  
WAGES ALONE.

MY, BUT  
THIS JUG IS  
QUITE EXPEN-  
SIVE.

NOW,  
NOT ONLY WILL YOU  
BE UNABLE TO SEND  
MONEY BACK TO  
YOUR FAMILY...



AND IF THAT'S NOT  
ENOUGH,  
TAKE IT OUT  
OF WHAT I RECEIVE  
TOO.



...I  
HUMBLY APOLO-  
GIZE FOR MY CLUMSI-  
NESS.

PLEASE  
DEDUCT THE  
COST FROM  
THE AMOUNT  
SENT BACK.



OH,  
AND...

I'LL  
MAKE THE ARRANGE-  
MENTS  
RIGHT AWAY.

VERY  
WELL.







SHE'S  
ALWAYS SO  
QUIET TOO...  
SHE MUSTN'T  
BE ABLE  
TO SPEAK  
PROPERLY  
ANYMORE.

...BUT  
THOSE  
WERE  
SCARS  
AND BURN  
MARKS,  
WEREN'T  
THEY?

SHE  
TRIES  
SO HARD  
TO HIDE IT  
WITH BAN-  
DAGES...

DID  
YOU SEE  
HER LEFT  
ARM? IT'S  
JUST AS I  
THOUGHT!



...I  
PITY  
THE  
POOR  
GIRL!

ABUSED  
BY HER  
PARENTS  
BEFORE  
BEING SOLD  
OFF TO THE  
PALACE...

...AND THEN  
CONDEMNED  
TO THE WORK  
OF A FOOD  
TASTER...

WAAAH...



AND EVERY FEW DAYS, I PARTAKE OF THE EMPEROR'S NUTRITIONALLY INVIGORATING DISHES THAT ARE SERVED DURING HIS VISITS. THAT'S IT.

TWO MEALS AND AFTER-NOON TEA.

I'M SUMMONED FOR FOOD TASTING THREE TIMES A DAY.



YOU'RE FREE TO RELAX UNTIL YOU'RE SENT FOR!



I'M STARTING TO FEEL LIKE LIVE-STOCK.



IN ADDITION TO THE DISHES I TEST FOR POISONS, MY USUAL MEALS HAVE ALSO GOTTEN A WHOLE LOT FANCIER.

URP



...THAT IT'S  
HARD FOR  
ME TO TELL  
IF I'M LOSING  
WEIGHT DUE  
TO A POISON  
SINCE I'M  
SKINNY TO  
BEGIN  
WITH.

IT'S  
TRUE  
...

THE  
MORE  
YOU  
WEIGH,  
THE MORE  
LIKELY YOU  
ARE TO  
SURVIVE.

A FATAL  
DOSE OF  
A POISON  
IS PRO-  
PORTIONAL  
TO THE  
SIZE OF  
ONE'S  
BODY.



WE'VE  
GOT  
SECONDS  
IF YOU  
WANT!

YOU  
SHOULD  
EAT  
MORE!

I'M  
NOT  
SURE  
ANYONE  
ELSE  
FEELS  
THE  
SAME,  
THOUGH.



AND  
I'M...

...ALSO  
CONFIDENT  
I'D SURVIVE  
MOST KINDS  
OF POISONS,  
EVEN IF I DID  
TAKE MORE  
THAN A FATAL  
DOSE.

BUT...

...I'M  
FAIRLY  
CERTAIN I'D  
RECOGNIZE  
POISON-  
INDUCED  
WEIGHT  
LOSS.

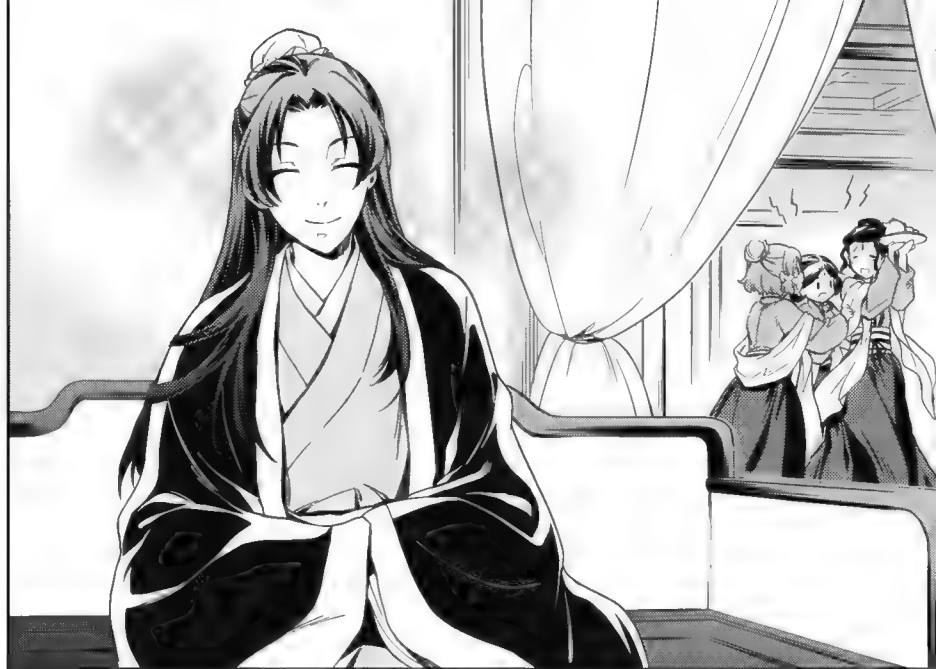


...BUT  
ALL I'VE  
BEEN ABLE  
TO BREW  
SINCE I GOT  
HERE IS  
HYDRANGEA  
TEA.

...AND  
CONCOCTED  
A VARIETY  
OF NEW  
MEDICINES  
AS AN  
APOTH-  
ECARY...

ONCE,  
I GOT TO  
EXPERIMENT  
ON MYSELF  
TO THE  
POINT OF  
MORTIFYING  
OTHERS...













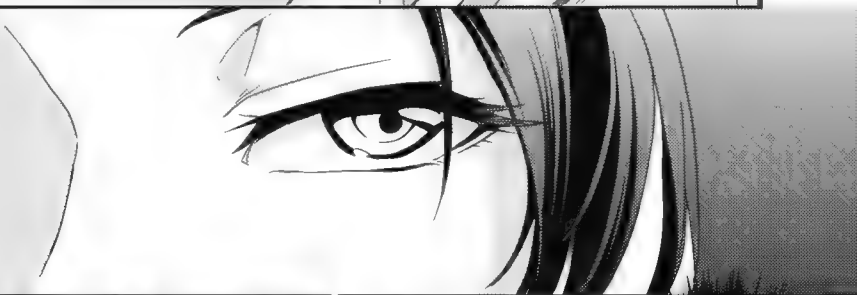


CAN  
I TASK  
YOU WITH  
MAKING AN  
APHRODISIAC  
FOR ME?

IF THAT'S  
ALL YOU  
REQUIRE  
TODAY,  
I SHALL  
TAKE MY  
LEAVE.

HA!  
HOW  
FUNNY!

I HAVE A  
REQUEST  
FOR YOU.



NO,  
WAIT.



FIRST  
HE TELLS  
ME TO TASTE  
SOMETHING  
WITH AN  
APHRODISIAC  
IN IT, NOW HE  
WANTS ME TO  
MAKE HIM  
ONE?

WHAT'S  
GOTTEN  
INTO HIM?





WITH  
AMPLE TIME,  
THE RIGHT  
TOOLS,  
AND THE  
NECESSARY  
INGREDI-  
ENTS...

...I CAN  
FULFILL  
YOUR  
REQUEST.





...BEEN  
INVITED  
INTO THE  
PRIVATE  
CHAMBERS  
OF THREE  
CONCUBINES  
OF VARYING  
RANKS.

...GIVEN  
APHRODI-  
SIAC-  
TAINTED  
FOOD BY  
A SOLDIER,  
AND TO  
TOP IT ALL  
OFF...

IN THE  
COURSE  
OF ONE  
DAY HERE,  
I'VE BEEN  
PROPOSI-  
TIONED BY  
A CIVIL  
SERVANT  
...

HOW VERY  
INSOLENT.

ATTEMPTING  
TO SEDUCE  
OTHER MEN  
BECAUSE THE  
EMPEROR  
WON'T VISIT  
THEM...



OF THE  
THREE,  
INTELLI-  
GENCE  
IS THE  
MOST  
STRICTLY  
GRADED.

IN  
ADDITION  
TO AN  
EDUCATION  
APPROPRI-  
ATE TO AN  
EMPRESS,  
IT REQUIRES  
A SENSE OF  
VIRTUE.

A  
CONCUBINE'S  
RANK IS  
DETERMINED  
BY HER  
LINEAGE,  
BEAUTY,  
AND  
INTELLI-  
GENCE.



POSTING  
ME TO  
THE INNER  
COURT FOR  
THE SAKE  
OF HIS  
SELEC-  
TIONS...

MY MASTER  
DOES HAVE A  
RATHER MEAN  
STREAK.



...HAVE  
REALIZED  
THAT MY  
PRESENCE  
HERE IS  
ITSELF  
A TEST  
OF THEIR  
CHARACTER.

I'M  
SURE A  
NUMBER  
OF THE  
LITTLE  
BIRDS  
TRAPPED  
IN THIS  
CAGE...



...AND  
CONSORT  
LIHUA,  
WHOSE  
DISPOSI-  
TION IS  
SECOND TO NONE  
...

...DESPITE  
THE RARE  
EMOTIONAL  
TURN.

THUS  
FAR, I'VE  
CHAMPIONED  
TWO WOMEN  
TO THE  
EMPEROR.

THE  
THOUGHT-  
FUL AND  
QUICK-  
WITTED  
CONSORT  
GYOKUYO  
...



HOW-  
EVER  
...

...CONSORT  
LIHUA IS  
BEYOND  
DEVOTED  
TO THE  
EMPEROR.

FAR FROM  
HARBORING  
ILL WILL  
TOWARD  
HIM...



...WAS  
AFTER  
THE  
CROWN  
PRINCE'S  
PASSING.

THE LAST  
TIME THE  
EMPEROR  
VISITED  
CONSORT  
LIHUA,  
WHO HAS  
ALL BUT  
WASTED  
AWAY...

...CONSORT  
GYOKUYO  
WILL MOST  
LIKELY  
CONTINUE  
AS THE  
FAVORITE.



MY  
MASTER  
OR NO,  
I HAVE  
TO ADMIT  
HE'S  
RATHER  
CRUEL.

...AND  
IF THEY  
ARE NO  
LONGER  
CAPABLE,  
DISCARDS  
THEM  
WITHOUT  
A SECOND  
THOUGHT.

...  
MAKES  
THEM  
BEAR  
HIS  
OFF-  
SPRING  
...

HE  
HOARDS  
ALL THESE  
WOMEN  
SUITABLE  
FOR  
HIMSELF  
AND THE  
NATION...



AH, THAT  
REMINDS  
ME...  
ONE OF THE  
MID-RANKING  
CONCUBINES  
IS TO BE  
BESTOWED  
UPON A  
MILITARY  
OFFICER.

...OR  
PASSED  
OFF TO  
OFFI-  
CIALS.

THOSE  
WHO ARE  
DEEMED  
UNWANTED  
ARE EITHER  
SENT BACK  
TO THEIR  
HOMES...



BUT  
TO DO SO,  
I MAY NEED  
TO PUT THAT  
HERBALIST  
TO MORE  
WORK  
YET...



ANYWAY,  
THERE  
SHOULD BE  
NO TROUBLE  
AS LONG AS  
I KEEP TO  
THE PLAN.



SHE  
JUST MIGHT  
TURN OUT  
TO BE MORE  
USEFUL THAN  
I COULD  
HAVE EVER  
IMAGINED.



...BUT  
SHE'S  
THE FIRST  
TO EVER  
LOOK AT  
ME LIKE  
THAT.

I'VE  
CERTAINLY  
MET MANY  
BEFORE  
WHO'VE  
TAKEN NO  
CARNAL  
INTEREST  
IN ME...

I'M  
SURE SHE  
MEANS TO  
HIDE IT...

...BUT  
THE WAY  
SHE KEEPS  
GLANCING  
AT ME AS  
ONE MIGHT  
A CATER-  
PILLAR...

GRIN  
ニヤ

GRIN  
ニヤ

じとみ  
STARE



Chapter 3 The Heavenly Maiden of the Court









IS HE A MILITARY MAN ...?

DOOM

MY NAME IS GAO SHUN.

HELLO, MISS MAOMAO.

ON A TYPICAL DAY, I AM SIR JINSHI'S AIDE.

UNLIKELY... SEEING AS HE'S HERE IN THE INNER COURT, HE MUST BE A EUNUCH.

I AM PLEASED TO MAKE YOUR ACQUAINTANCE.

AS AM I.

NO  
BOW

THIS WAY, IF YOU PLEASE.

THANK YOU.



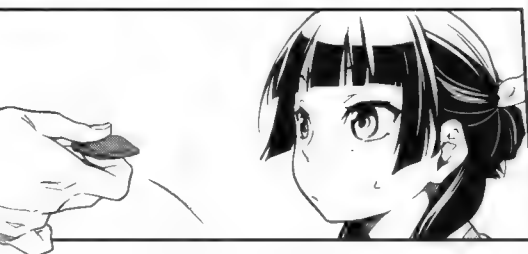










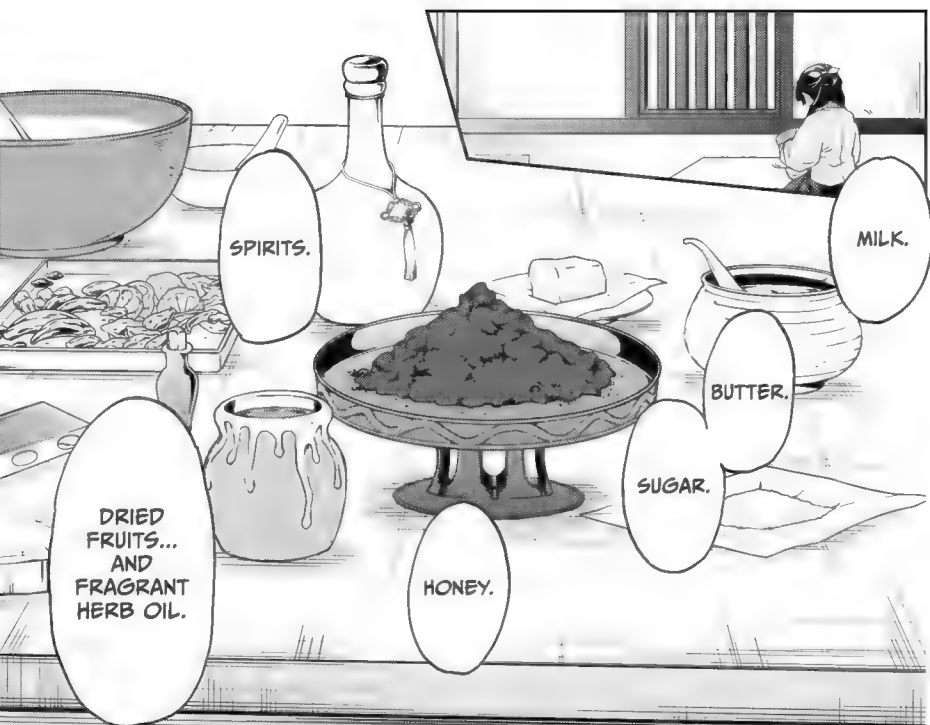


SNIFF

SNIFF











...LET'S  
MAKE  
US AN  
APHRO-  
DISIAC!

NOW...



NEXT,  
FINELY  
SLICE THE  
BUTTER AND  
THROW THAT  
IN TOO.

FIRST,  
COMBINE  
THE CACAO  
POWDER  
AND SUGAR  
IN A BOWL.

SPRINKLE  
サ  
ヲ







IN WHICH CASE, I GUESS...

...FINDING THAT IN THE HEIGHT OF SUMMER IS UNLIKELY.

LOOK  
きき

LOOK  
きき

NOW, SOME ICE SHOULD BE PERFECT FOR HARDENING IT, BUT...



ん TAK



...THAT WILL HAVE TO DO.



THIS TEMPERATURE SHOULD BE JUST RIGHT FOR SOLIDIFYING THE FATS.

NICE AND COOL



CLOSE IT WITH A LID, AND AS THE WATER WITHIN EVAPORATES, THE INSIDE OF THE JUG WILL GROW COLDER THAN THE TEMPERATURE OUTSIDE IT.

FILL A WATER JUG MADE OF UNGLAZED POTTERY HALFWAY.

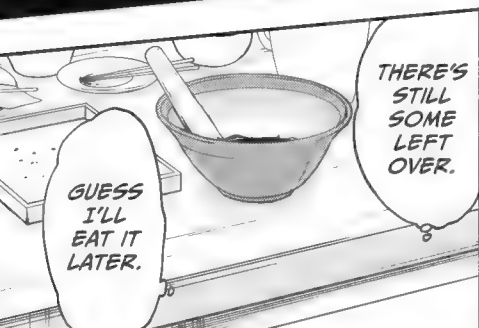


LINE THE  
PIECES UP  
ON A PLATE,  
THEN FLOAT  
THE PLATE  
ON THE  
SURFACE OF  
THE WATER IN  
THE JUG.

PLOP  
ちやぽ

FINELY  
CHOP THE  
DRIED FRUITS,  
THEN DIP  
THEM IN THE  
CHOCOLATE.

PUT ON  
THE LID,  
COVERING  
IT WITH A  
WOVEN  
STRAW  
MAT.



GUESS  
I'LL  
EAT IT  
LATER.

THERE'S  
STILL  
SOME  
LEFT  
OVER.



WELL  
...

...AND  
NOW  
WE  
WAIT.

...THEY  
SHOULD BE  
READY BY  
THE TIME  
HE GETS  
HERE.

PHEW!



OH,  
I'VE  
GOT  
AN  
IDEA.



I'LL CUT  
BREAD INTO  
CUBES...

...TO  
SOP UP THE  
LEFTOVER  
CHOCOLATE.

い  
あ  
あ  
SOAK



I THINK  
I CAN SKIP  
THE COOLING  
THIS WAY...



NOW...

...GUESS  
I'D BETTER  
SEE TO THE  
WASHING-  
UP.

MIND  
TAKING  
THIS  
TOO?

DOING  
SOME  
DISHES?



THERE'S  
HERBS  
GROWING  
HERE?

OOH!



AND  
HERE  
TOO!

OOH!

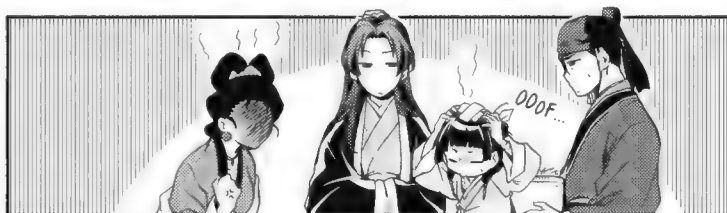




SIGH











MY  
LATE-  
NIGHT  
SNACK.

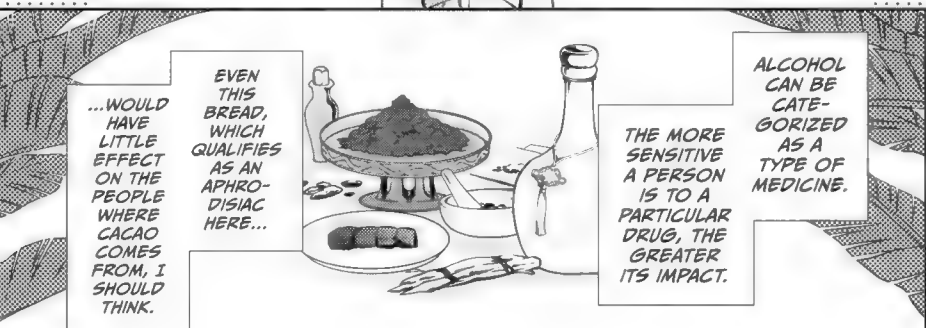
THEN WHAT  
ARE THESE  
FOR?



I'VE  
BUILT UP A  
TOLERANCE  
FOR  
ALCOHOL  
AND STIMU-  
LANTS...

...SO  
THEY  
DON'T  
DO TOO  
MUCH TO  
ME.

BLUNT



...WOULD  
HAVE  
LITTLE  
EFFECT  
ON THE  
PEOPLE  
WHERE  
CACAO  
COMES  
FROM, I  
SHOULD  
THINK.

EVEN  
THIS  
BREAD,  
WHICH  
QUALIFIES  
AS AN  
APHRO-  
DISIAC  
HERE...

THE MORE  
SENSITIVE  
A PERSON  
IS TO A  
PARTICULAR  
DRUG, THE  
GREATER  
ITS IMPACT.

ALCOHOL  
CAN BE  
CATE-  
GORIZED  
AS A  
TYPE OF  
MEDICINE.



...WERE  
TO COME ON  
TO SOMEONE  
WITH A BLUSH  
ON HIS FACE...

...WITH  
THOSE  
LOOKS...

I SUPPOSE  
BEING SO  
GRATUITOUSLY  
BLESSED WITH  
BEAUTY IS ITS  
OWN KIND OF  
PROBLEM.

...I'M  
SURE IT  
WOULD BE  
ENOUGH TO  
MAKE ANYONE  
LOSE THEIR  
HEAD, MAN  
OR WOMAN.

OH MY YYY

WHOO

OOA!

INGEST  
TOO MANY,  
AND THE  
INCREASED  
BLOOD FLOW  
WILL CAUSE A  
NOSEBLEED.

IT'S QUITE  
EFFECTIVE,  
SO PLEASE  
ONLY EAT  
ONE PIECE  
AT A TIME.

す  
SWISH

A WARNING  
ABOUT THE  
APHRODI-  
SIAC...





EXCUSE  
US!



WE'LL  
DO THE  
SAME,  
THEN.

SWF  
す



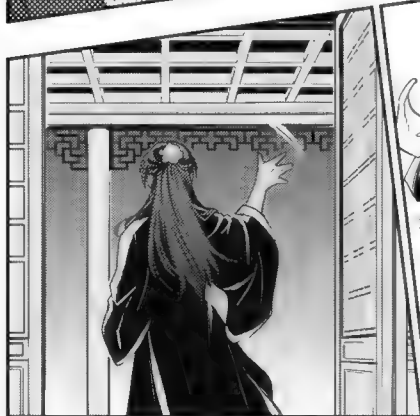
GLAD  
THAT'S  
FINALLY  
OVER.

PHEW!



MY  
THANKS...

...FOR  
GOING  
TO ALL  
THAT  
TROU-  
BLE.



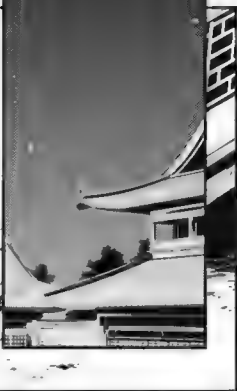
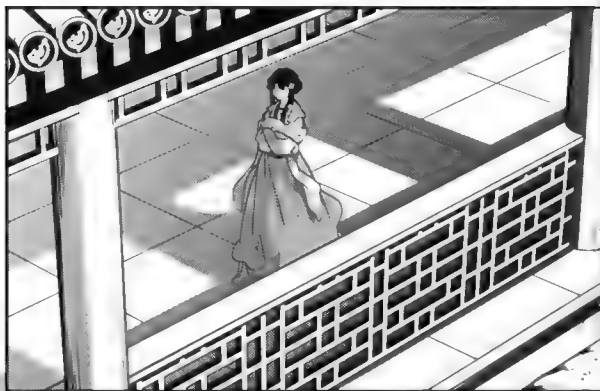


NOW  
I SEE  
WHAT  
YOU  
WERE  
AFTER.





...WELL,  
JUST AS  
LONG AS  
NO ONE  
GETS  
HURT.





EEK!

## Chapter 4 The Moonlight Ghost





YOU  
THINK  
SO  
TOO?!

I WALK  
BY THAT  
EXACT  
SPOT  
PRETTY  
OFTEN  
MYSELF!



I WONDER  
IF IT WAS  
THAT GHOST  
IN WHITE  
I'VE BEEN  
HEARING  
ABOUT  
LATELY.



BUBBLE

BUBBLE

THAT'S  
WHAT  
SHE SAID  
HAPPENED,  
AT LEAST.

HMM...

A  
GHOSTLY  
WOMAN  
DANCING  
ATOP THE  
PALACE  
WALLS,  
NIGHT  
AFTER  
NIGHT...

IT'S  
BEEN GOING  
ON FOR THE  
PAST MONTH  
OR SO.





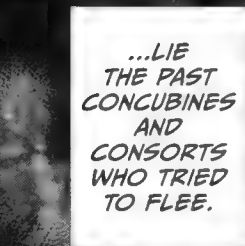
IT'S  
IMPOSSIBLE  
TO ESCAPE  
OR TO TRY  
TO SLIP IN  
THROUGH  
THEM.

EACH  
GATE IS  
GUARDED  
BY TWO  
EUNUCHS  
ON THE  
INSIDE...  
...AND TWO  
GUARDS  
ON THE  
OUTSIDE.



THE  
GATES  
LOCATED  
IN EACH  
CARDINAL  
DIRECTION  
ARE THE  
ONLY WAYS  
IN AND  
OUT.

THE  
INNER  
COURT IS  
ENCIRCLED  
BY WALLS  
AND A  
MOAT.



...LIE  
THE PAST  
CONCUBINES  
AND  
CONSORTS  
WHO TRIED  
TO FLEE.



IT'S  
SAID THAT  
AT THE  
BOTTOM  
OF THE  
DEEP  
MOAT  
BEYOND  
THE  
WALLS...



THIS  
LATEST  
RUMOR ISN'T  
EVEN ALL THAT  
UNUSUAL FOR  
THE INNER  
COURT, WHERE  
GHOST STORIES  
ARE OFTEN  
PASSED  
AROUND.



...THAT HE'S STARTED BEING MORE CORDIAL TO ME.

I GUESS IT'S BECAUSE HE KNOWS I CAN MAKE MEDICINE...



OH, IT'S YOU, MISS.

MAY I TAKE A LOOK AT YOUR STORES?

JUST A MOMENT.



...THAT WOULD BE BREAKING HIS DUTY OF CONFIDENTIALITY TO HIS PATIENTS.

AND EVEN IF I WERE TO OFFER TO MAKE THEM IN HIS PLACE...

...BUT HE KNOWS ONLY THE BARE MINIMUM ABOUT CRAFTING REMEDIES HIMSELF.

I APPRECIATE HIM SHARING INGREDIENTS...



I'VE MADE US TEA.

OH! HE'S EVEN GOT RICE CRACKERS!



HE'S A NICE ENOUGH GUY BUT TERRIBLE AT HIS JOB.







I'LL  
JUST GO  
AHEAD AND  
ASSUME  
HE'S THE  
EMPEROR'S  
LOVER.



I'M  
NOT SURE  
WHAT YOU  
COULD  
POSSIBLY  
MEAN.

WHY DOES  
YOUR FACE  
SAY YOU'RE  
THINKING  
SOMETHING  
INCREDIBLY  
INDECENT  
RIGHT  
NOW?



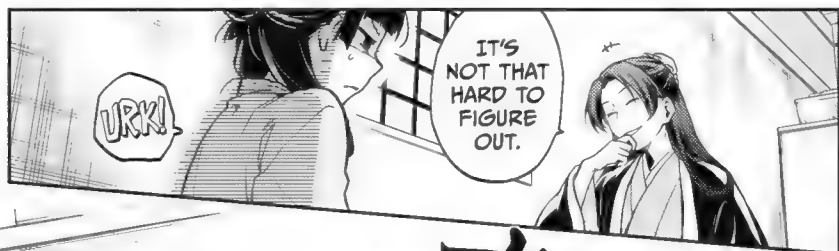
CAN I  
TROUBLE  
YOU TO  
GET THESE  
FROM THE  
BACK FOR  
ME?



OH YES,  
DOCTOR.

JIN  
RUSTLE









WHAT  
A  
PAIN!

WH...



HE  
STICKS  
TO YOU  
LIKE  
GLUE!



SHUDDER

SHUDDER

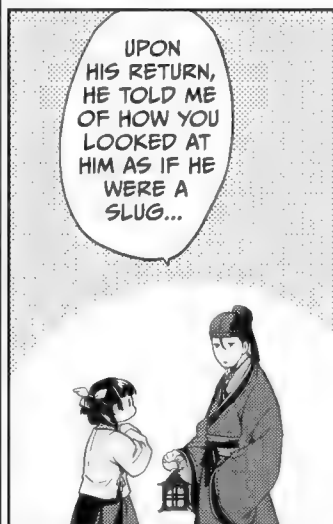
...I'LL  
SEE  
WHAT  
I CAN  
DO.





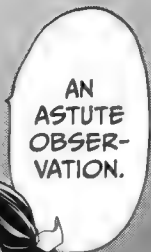
\*XIAO MEANS "LITTLE."













A  
PRINCESS  
WHO, IN A  
MONTH'S  
TIME...



...WILL  
BE GIFTED  
TO AN ARMY  
OFFICER  
IN REWARD  
FOR HIS DIS-  
TINGUISHED  
SERVICE.



...  
HASN'T  
BEEN  
WELL  
OF  
LATE.

NOW  
THAT YOU  
MENTION  
IT, LADY  
FUYO...



SHE'S  
BEEN AT THE  
INNER COURT  
FOR TWO  
YEARS, BUT  
SHE'S NEVER  
SPENT A NIGHT  
WITH THE  
EMPEROR.

I'VE  
HEARD  
SHE'S  
THE THIRD  
PRINCESS  
OF A SMALL  
VASSAL  
STATE.

...SO  
HOPEFULLY  
SHE FINDS  
HAPPINESS  
WITH HIM.

WELL,  
I'VE HEARD  
THAT THE  
ARMY MAN  
SHE'S BEING  
GIVEN TO IS  
ACTUALLY A  
CHILDHOOD  
FRIEND...



HMM...

SLEEP-  
WALKING  
IS AN  
AILMENT  
THAT'S NOT  
TERRIBLY  
WELL  
UNDER-  
STOOD.





IT  
CAN'T  
BE  
CURED  
WITH  
MEDI-  
CINE.

THE  
CAUSE IS A  
CONFLICT  
OF THE  
HEART.

EVEN  
THOUGH  
YOU'RE  
ASLEEP,  
YOU WALK  
AROUND  
AND ACT AS  
IF YOU'RE  
AWAKE.



SHE WAS  
CHEERFUL  
AND GOOD  
AT POETRY.

I ONCE  
HAD A  
SLEEP-  
WALKING  
PATIENT  
WHO  
RESIDED  
IN A  
BROTHEL.



...BECAUSE  
SHE BEGAN  
WALKING  
THROUGH  
THE BROTHEL  
NIGHT AFTER  
NIGHT AS IF  
POSSESSED.



SHE EVEN  
RECEIVED A  
PROPOSAL  
FROM A  
CLIENT WHO  
WISHED TO  
BUY HER  
FREEDOM...

...BUT HE  
BROKE  
OFF THE  
NEGOTIA-  
TIONS...



THE NEXT  
MORNING,  
THE OTHER  
RESIDENT  
COURTESANS  
APPROACHED  
THE WOMAN  
CAUTIOUSLY.



WHEN THE  
BROTHEL-  
KEEPER  
TRIED TO  
STOP  
HER...

...THE  
WOMAN  
CLAWED  
AWAY  
WITH  
HER  
NAILS.

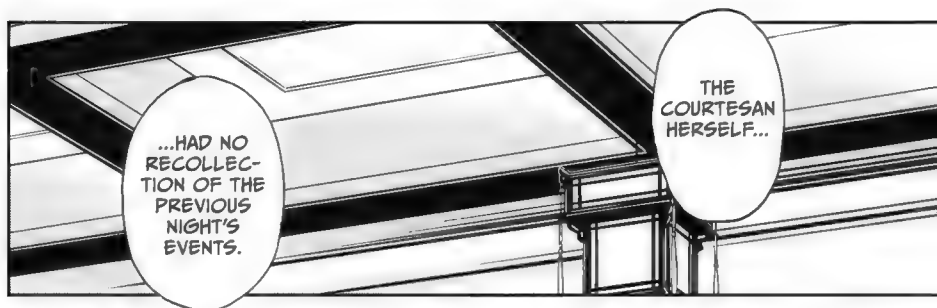


SEEING  
THEM,  
SHE  
SAID...



WHY  
DO YOU  
LOOK AT  
ME LIKE  
THAT?

OH?



...HAD NO RECOLLEC-  
TION OF THE  
PREVIOUS  
NIGHT'S  
EVENTS.

THE  
COURTESAN  
HERSELF...



AFTER  
THE  
TALKS  
FOR HER  
FREEDOM  
BROKE  
OFF...

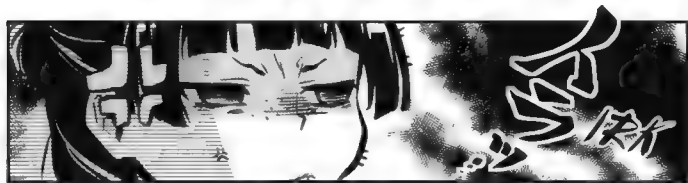
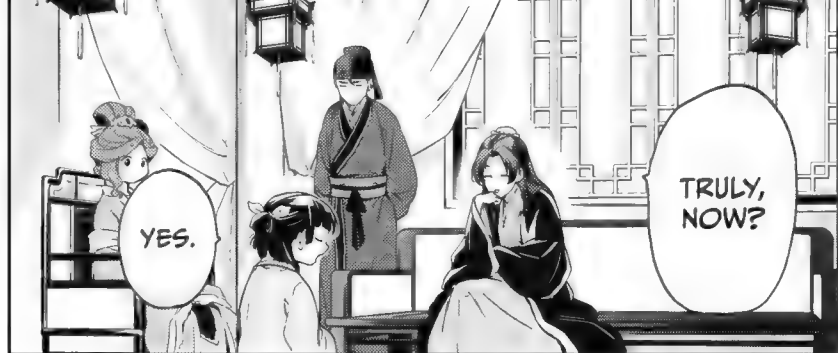
...SHE  
CEASED  
HER  
NIGHTLY  
WANDER-  
ING.



SO WHAT  
HAPPENED  
THEN?

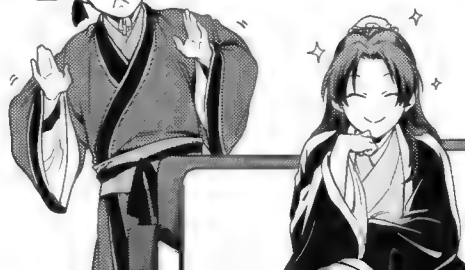
NOTHING.



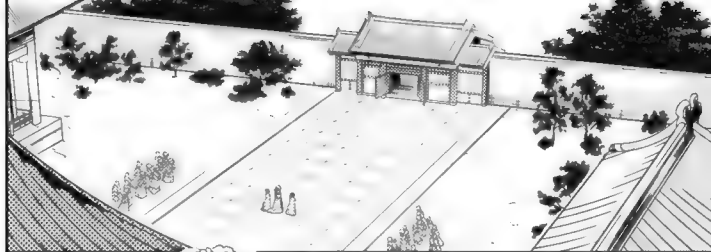


STAY STRONG!

HOLD IT IN!









CAN'T YOU  
AT LEAST  
TELL ME?



THIS IS  
MERELY  
CONJEC-  
TURE...

...SO  
PLEASE  
DON'T  
TAKE ANY  
OFFENSE.



MY  
LIPS ARE  
SEALED!

WELL,  
IF YOU  
PROMISE  
NOT TO  
TELL  
ANYONE  
...

TEE-  
HEE!



I'M  
THE ONE  
ASKING.  
I WON'T  
GET  
UPSET.



...THERE WAS  
ANOTHER WHO  
SUFFERED FROM  
SLEEPWALKING  
AND SIMILARLY  
HAD NEGOTIA-  
TIONS FOR HER  
FREEDOM FALL  
THROUGH.

...IN  
ADDITION  
TO THE  
COURTESAN  
I MENTIONED  
BEFORE...



...THAT  
COURTESAN  
LATER WOUND  
UP WITH A  
SECOND  
OFFER  
FOR HER  
FREEDOM.

AS IT  
TURNED  
OUT,  
HOW-  
EVER...



HOWEVER,  
THE MAN  
PERSISTED.



...  
TURNED  
HIM  
DOWN.

I CANNOT  
BEAR THE IDEA  
OF ALLOWING  
YOU TO TAKE  
ON AN ILL  
COURTESAN.

THE  
MADAM  
THERE  
...



EVENTUALLY,  
THEY AGREED  
ON A PRICE  
OF HALF THE  
SILVER FROM  
THE ORIGINAL  
AGREEMENT.



...IT  
WAS ALL  
A RUSE.

BUT...



...WAS AN  
ACQUAINTANCE  
OF THE  
SECOND.

THE  
FIRST  
MAN WHO  
HAD TRIED  
TO BUY HER  
FREEDOM  
...



HOW  
SO?



AND  
THEN  
...

...THE  
MAN TO  
WHOM  
SHE TRULY  
WANTED HER  
FREEDOM  
SOLD WAS  
ABLE TO  
BUY IT FOR  
HALF THE  
PRICE.

THE  
WOMAN  
FEIGNED  
ILLNESS  
TO NULLIFY  
THE INITIAL  
OFFER.



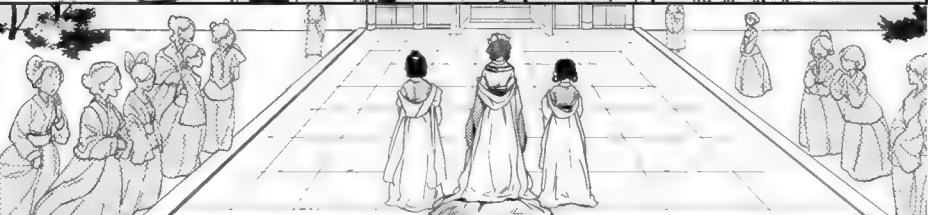
...WHILE  
THE MAN'S  
HANDS WERE  
TIED BY THE  
LACK OF  
SILVER.

THE  
COURTESAN  
WAS BOUND  
TO THE  
TERMS  
OF HER  
CONTRACT  
...



AS  
I SAID,  
THIS IS  
JUST MY  
GUESS.

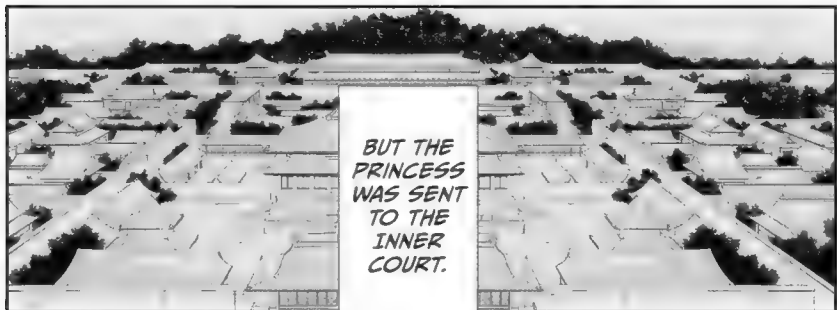
SO YOU  
MEAN TO SAY  
LADY FUYO IS  
PRETENDING  
WITH THE  
SAME  
INTENT?



...BEFORE  
EVENTUALLY  
RETURNING  
TO MAKE THE  
PRINCESS  
HIS.

SO  
THE PLAN  
WAS TO  
ACCU-  
MULATE  
MERITS  
FOR HIS  
MILITARY  
FEATS...

A MERE  
SOLDIER  
IS IN NO  
POSITION  
TO ASK  
FOR A  
PRINCESS'S  
HAND IN  
MARRIAGE.

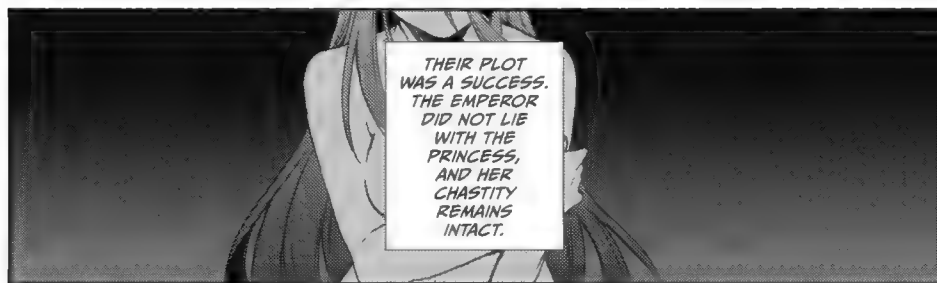


BUT THE  
PRINCESS  
WAS SENT  
TO THE  
INNER  
COURT.



...TO  
CAUSE THE  
EMPEROR  
TO LOSE  
INTEREST  
IN HER.

HAVING  
LIKEWISE  
GIVEN HER  
HEART  
TO THE  
SOLDIER,  
THE  
PRINCESS—  
AN ADEPT  
DANCER—  
PURPOSELY  
ERRED...



THEIR PLOT  
WAS A SUCCESS.  
THE EMPEROR  
DID NOT LIE  
WITH THE  
PRINCESS,  
AND HER  
CHASTITY  
REMAINS  
INTACT.



...LADY FUYO  
BEGAN HER  
STRANGE  
NIGHTLY  
RAMBLES...

...AND  
WHEN  
IT WAS  
DECIDED  
SHE WAS  
TO BE  
HIS...

THE  
SOLDIER,  
MEAN-  
WHILE,  
MADE  
A NAME  
FOR  
HIMSELF  
...



...AND  
SO THE  
EMPEROR  
WOULDN'T  
CARE  
THAT SHE  
WOULDN'T  
BE HIS ANY  
LONGER...

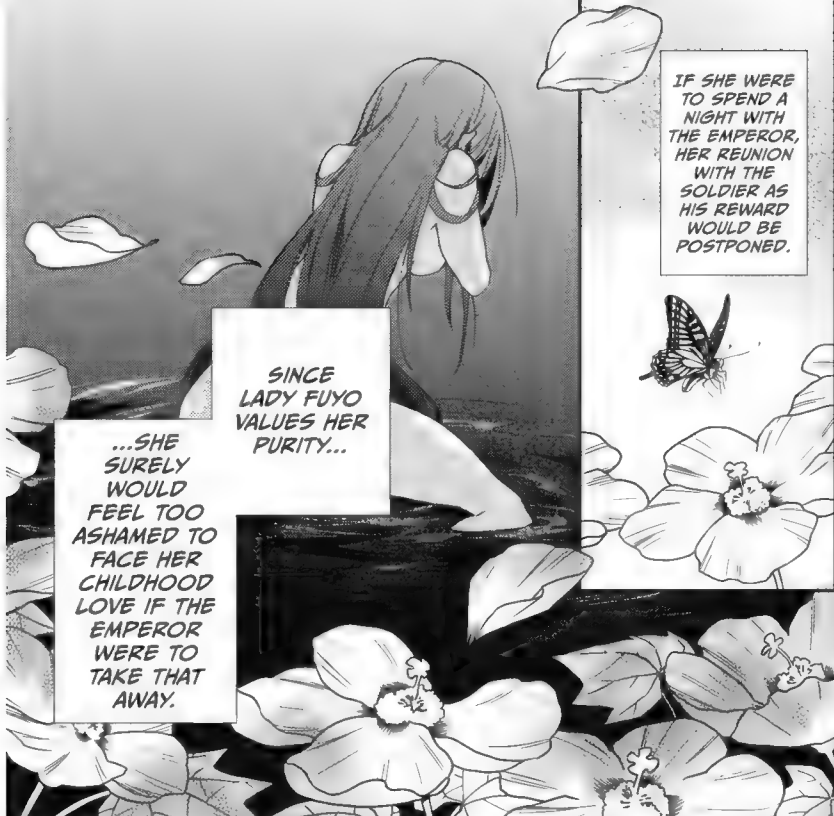
...SO  
NONE  
WOULD  
DEFLOWER  
HER, EVEN  
BY MISTAKE  
...



THERE  
IS,  
AFTER  
ALL, A  
CHANCE  
...

...THAT  
THE LUSTY  
EMPEROR  
MIGHT REGAIN  
INTEREST IN A  
PRINCESS SO  
COVETED BY  
ONE OF HIS  
MEN.

I COULD  
SEE THAT  
HAPPENING,  
KNOWING  
WHAT THE  
EMPEROR  
IS LIKE.



IF SHE WERE  
TO SPEND A  
NIGHT WITH  
THE EMPEROR,  
HER REUNION  
WITH THE  
SOLDIER AS  
HIS REWARD  
WOULD BE  
POSTPONED.

SINCE  
LADY FUYO  
VALUES HER  
PURITY...

...SHE  
SURELY  
WOULD  
FEEL TOO  
ASHAMED TO  
FACE HER  
CHILDHOOD  
LOVE IF THE  
EMPEROR  
WERE TO  
TAKE THAT  
AWAY.

...WOULD  
THAT  
MAKE ME  
AN AWFUL  
PERSON?

IF I SAID I  
ENVIED LADY  
FUYO...



BUT IT'S  
NOT JUST  
COURTLY  
DUTIES  
THAT  
KEEP THE  
EMPEROR  
AWAY.

THE  
EMPEROR  
ONLY  
CALLS ON  
CONSORT  
GYOKUYO  
EVERY  
FEW  
DAYS.



HIS  
IMPERIAL  
MAJESTY  
ALSO HAS  
A DUTY TO  
FATHER  
MULTIPLE  
HEIRS.



I  
DON'T  
THINK  
SO.



...MUST  
ENVY  
THIS  
HAPPY  
SCENE.

EVERY-  
ONE  
HERE...



SHE  
PROBABLY  
DANCED AT  
THE EAST  
GATE IN  
PARTICU-  
LAR...

...BECAUSE  
HER BELOVED  
WAS COMING  
HOME FROM  
AN EXPEDI-  
TION IN THE  
EAST.

SHE  
MUST HAVE  
BEEN PRAYING  
FOR THE SAFE  
RETURN OF HER  
CHILDHOOD  
FRIEND.



NOW  
I GET  
IT.

THAT  
EXQUISITE  
APPEAR-  
ANCE...

IT'S  
BECAUSE  
SHE'S IN  
LOVE.

THAT  
NIGHT,  
LADY  
FUYO  
LOOKED  
EXCEP-  
TIONALLY  
BEAUTIFUL.



IF LOVE  
HAS THE  
POWER  
TO MAKE  
WOMEN  
MORE  
BEAUTIFUL  
...



...I  
WONDER  
WHAT IT  
COULD  
CURE.

# The Apothecary Diaries



# SPECIAL THANKS

Thank you so much for buying  
*The Apothecary Diaries*, Volume 1!

I hope readers of the  
wonderful original light novel  
and new readers alike enjoyed  
this volume!

And I hope to see you again  
in the next volume!

From the artist,  
Nekokurage:

| ORIGINAL                     | COMPILATION     | ASSISTANTS                        |
|------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------|
| Natsu Hyuruga<br>Touco Shino | Itsuki<br>Nanao | Waka Takase<br>Rie Shiroyi<br>105 |

My editor & you, my readers

SPECIAL THANKS

MAOMAO IS CURRENTLY SERVING AS A LADY-IN-WAITING AT THE JADE PALACE.

*ZZZZZZ...*

SLEEPING SOUNDLY NEXT TO ME RIGHT NOW IS MY FRIEND MAOMAO.

HELLO, I'M XIAOLAN, A MAID.

...BUT SHE SEEMS KINDA TIRED TODAY.

*Z*

SOMETIMES WE GET TOGETHER TO CHAT ABOUT THE LATEST TRENDS AND GOSSIP...

SORRY I FELL ASLEEP!

**GASP**

I DIDN'T GET TO FIND OUT ANYTHING NEW FROM HER TODAY.

SEE YA LATER!

WELL, BETTER GET BACK TO WORK!

IT'S OKAY!

WHY IS SHE BEHIND ME?

WHY  
IS  
YOUR  
HAIR  
LIKE  
THAT?

WH—

WHAT  
THE  
—?!

GAH!

?

LIKE  
WHAT?

HOPE  
SHE  
LIKES  
IT!  
♡

I DID  
HER HAIR  
IN THE  
STYLE  
THAT'S  
REALLY  
POPULAR  
WITH THE  
MAIDS  
LATELY.

SPECIAL  
♡ THANKS ♡

Natsu Hyuuga

Touco Shino

Nekokurage

The editor

And you, the readers

The next volume's going  
to be good too, so be  
sure to check it out!

七緒一綺  
Itsuki Nanao



Thank you for buying Volume I of *The Apothecary Diaries*.

My name is Natsu Hyuuga. I'm the author of the light novel series this manga is based on. What started off as a light novel I posted online got picked up for publication, and now it's even been turned into a manga. I'm amazed at how far this title has come.

I was overcome with emotion when my story got the color insert illustration treatment, but seeing the characters now come alive frame by frame has allowed me to enjoy the story all over again as a reader too.

The world and characters I couldn't completely describe in the novel are going to be more fleshed out in the manga, so I hope the readers of the novel will enjoy this version as well.

Natsu Hyuuga





Maomao and the delightfully weird cast of characters are now a manga! I hope you thoroughly enjoy the world of *The Apothecary Diaries* in this retelling that keeps the wit of the novels through its many lovely pages. I hope you especially enjoy Maomao's many facial expressions.

# The Apothecary Diaries **1**

The Manga

Novel illustrator

しとうこ  
Touko Shino

# INTENSELY SELF-CONSCIOUS



# THE GIRL ON EVERYONE'S MIND



MAOMAO'S WEIGHT LOSS METHOD:  
GETTING TOTALLY ABSORBED IN  
RUNNING AROUND COLLECTING  
HERBS AS FAST AS POSSIBLE

AND  
ANOTHER!

PASH

THERE'S  
ANOTHER!

OOOH,  
LOOK  
WHAT  
I'VE  
FOUND  
HERE  
...!

PASH

OVER  
HERE  
TOO!!

zoom

I SURE  
WORKED  
UP A GOOD  
SWEAT.

YOU TOO  
CAN LOSE FIVE  
KILOS WITH THIS  
METHOD!



# The Apothecary Diaries

## Volume 1

*Story by*  
**Natsu Hyuuga**

*Art by*  
**Nekokurage**

*Compiled by*  
**Itsuki Nanao**

*Character Design by*  
**Touco Shino**

Translation: Julie Goniwich

Lettering: Lys Blakeslee

Cover Design: Andrea Miller

Editor: Tania Biswas

THE APOTHECARY DIARIES Volume 1

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